

## Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

There may be times during these five steps that you think we've veered off course a little, when you start to wonder what the topics and exercises we're discussing have to do with money. But you're going to have to trust me, because in order to make something work well, you have to exercise and strengthen the surrounding muscles too. Superficial fixes for financial problems are easy to come by – but all of the tips and tricks in the world won't fix a relationship with money that is fundamentally broken. The boundary between our finances and the rest of our lives, in so far as it exists, is porous in both directions; what we do with our money has an effect on everything else, but the way that we look after ourselves and the decisions that we make elsewhere affect our financial situation too.

### **Remember that your money doesn't exist in a vacuum**

Money is also, of course, not just about personal finance. It is a political and societal issue, influencing – even deciding – the power structures in every sphere, from offices to governments. Our relationship with money as a species has a long history, and the societal narratives that have built up around wealth and hardship have been heavily influenced by everything from war to religion. We are encouraged to measure our success in pounds sterling, but it's important to remember that this path to 'success', as dictated by culture and society, isn't a running track. It's a treadmill, or a hamster wheel. There is no